

Observe

The observatory floor is filthy with the footprints of students who skipped the welcome mat, opting to drag their muddy boots along the tile.

You scrubbed this floor yesterday. You scrubbed it so hard that you convinced yourself you added a permanent, protective layer on the surface. To your dismay, it's even worse tonight. Perhaps the extra scrubbing force created microscopic indents, perfect for holding dirt. You shake your head, chuckling at the thought.

As you are re-dipping the mop, you hear the unmistakable sound of a chair scooting violently against the building's antique hardwood. That definitely left a mark. Your reaction seems to have disturbed someone nearby. This is strange, not only because your laugh was barely louder than a pindrop, but also the fact that the observatory closes at 12:00AM and the clock reads 1:10.

You turn to your right, locking eyes with a girl in the neighboring room. She is in the physics & astronomy library, fearlessly leaning back in one of the rickety chairs. You know she shouldn't be here, but you're also not one to confront a student who is seemingly just trying to study. Either way, you don't get paid enough to kick students out.

You look away to continue mopping, but you can sense her gaze still upon you. The prolonged silence indicates that the chair is still hovering above ground. You turn back to face her again. "Are you alright? You know, the observatory closed over an hour ago. You shouldn't be here."

She quickly fixes her position and responds with an unexpected apology. "I'm so sorry, I hadn't realised. Thank you for telling me."

You grab the *Wet Floor* sign off your cart and place it onto the shiny ground. Just then, her voice starts up again.

"And I'm sorry for staring, I was just very concentrated on studying, so my mind got really focused on the small distraction. You know how it is."

You don't know how it is. You never went to college, and God knows you didn't study until 1:00AM in High School.

"Yeah, I get it. It's fine."

She hurries to grab the pile of papers sprawled across the giant library table. There's no grace in her movement as she folds and crushes documents, shoveling them into her backpack.

"Hey, if you're in a rhythm here, you can stay to finish. Just leave within the hour."

Her shoulders relax, but you think she probably expected you to say that.

"You're the best, really. I have two questions left so I'll be out soon I promise."

She turns on a radio propped next to one of the bookcases nearby and sits back down. As you walk away, a sudden sharp, frigid breeze hits your face. It's winter, January, but it shouldn't be

cold *inside*. Not unless the central heating was out. The building is small, maybe five or six rooms. It has one thermostat which controls the temperature throughout. You check this dial. It reads 68°F, but it is definitely not that warm.

You are already wearing a hoodie, but now your winter jacket seems necessary. You put it on and notice as the girl in the library does the same, pulling her coat off the ground, eyes still glued to her textbook. She wraps it around herself and zips it tight to her chin, before picking her pencil up again.

The sudden temperature change is abnormal, there was no warning for this afternoon. You know because you listen to the radio's forecast every day. The bus system here is reliable, but there have been a few times where an unexpected storm delayed or canceled your ride home. You check the thermostat again, hoping to blame the discrepancy on your worsening eyesight, but it still reads 68°F. You sigh into the neck of your jacket. The warm air heats your neck.

Stepping away, you reach a rotary phone secured to the wall behind the front desk. You take a crumpled paper out of your pocket, reading off your sister's number and dialing each digit carefully. As it rings, you read the phone's branding, *Western Electric*. The metal base is an ugly shade of yellow that almost hurts your head. The line rings and rings, but your call is eventually answered.

"Jennifer speaking, who's this?"

"Sissy, it's me."

"I should've known, who else would wake me—"

"Listen, I'm at work. Can you do me a favor?"

"I mean, sure. What do you want?"

"Can you turn on the radio, check if there's a storm coming?"

"Are they even live at this hour?"

"Can you just check?"

"Alright, jeez. Give me a minute."

There is a long pause. You look out the window next to the phone, peeking between the curtains. It's pitch black aside from a lamppost next to the front door, which lights up cans and tissues laying on the grass beside a half empty trashcan. You'll pick it up when you leave tonight. Your eyes shift to a shipping container in the distance. It's maybe 100 steps away. You've worked here for over six months, but haven't seen this before. You don't remember it being there when you came in either, but maybe you just missed it. As you squint to try and make out any writing on the container, your sister's voice abruptly reemerges, causing you to jump backwards and hold your chest. You turn around, leaning your back against the cold window.

"Okay, I listened for a while. They didn't say nothing."

"Really, you sure?"

"Yeah, they just said it might rain on Sunday."

"Nothing about tonight?"

"No, why?"

"It's just really cold, so I w—"

“Wait, they did say something. What did they say...”

Another pause ensues. This time you stay fixed in position.

“A meteor, that’s it. Like a big rock. It’s gonna fly by tonight, right over us I think.”

“Okay.”

“Wait, aren’t you cleaning at an observatron tonight? You should look for it in the sky.”

“It’s *observatory*, and no.”

“Jeez, you’re so boring. I’m going back to sleep.”

Wait, you can’t let her leave yet. You haven’t annoyed her enough.

“There’s a—”

“Whaaaat do you want?”

“There’s a girl here, in the library.”

“And? So?”

“Nothing, I just thought I should tell you.”

“...You’re weird...”

“So you know that some people actually study hard.”

You look away to let out a small laugh.

“Now what’s that mean?”

“Nothing at all...”

“BYE!”

The dial tone rings and you place the phone on the wall. As you get back to work, you fall into the nightly routine and the minutes pass quickly. Before you know it, it’s 2:00AM.

Returning to the library, you search for the girl but she isn’t there. You know she hasn’t left the building because her bag and papers remain in place. While walking past the table, you scan her notebook which is covered in equations. Some of the equations don’t even have numbers, just symbols. You don’t know how anyone could enjoy such a subject, but it’s impressive nonetheless. Her name is written at the top of the page. *Michelle Davis*. There’s a school ID lanyard sitting next to her pencil case, brandishing the same name and a proud, gummy-smile headshot.

You reach the other side of the library and push against the massive stone door to the telescope room. It’s the last room you need to clean, but you figure that she’s probably in there as well. Light from the library enters the room in a sharp line as you walk through, illuminating the girl who is standing with her eye against the telescope.

“Come on, it’s time to go.”

“Wait, wait.”

“It’s 2:00AM. Let’s go, get your stuff.”

“Okay, just wait. It will be here soon.”

“What? What will be here?”

“There’s a meteor, it’s passing by here tonight.”

“Yeah, I know. Is that why you’re still here?”

“Ha, yea– Well, I really was studying before, but yea. I heard it on the radio.”

You don’t respond. Maybe she’ll take your silence as a sign to leave.

“Why don’t you come see? It’s any minute now.”

She reaches out a hand to you while still looking through the scope. You approach slowly but don’t take her hand. She pulls it away, not out of offense, but to readjust the lens. You’ve never seen a meteor before. You wonder how it’s even visible, if it’s just a rock. Does it catch fire as a result of its speed, lighting up a trail in its wake?

“Oh my God! Here, here. It’s here!”

She moves away, pointing to the telescope.

“Look, quickly.”

You move to take her spot, bending over and squinting through the glass. There’s definitely something there. There’s a light. It’s blinking, but it’s not flying through the air. It’s stationary. You don’t want to be a buzzkill, but you’re pretty sure that’s just a star, or maybe one of those satellites. Her voice interrupts your thought process and she lightly shoves you aside.

“Alright, come on. Let me see again. It’s probably gone by n–”

She stops abruptly as her eyes focus and she realizes what she’s seeing. You interject the silence with a question.

“Are you sure that’s a meteor?”

“What the...?”

“What?”

“That’s... That’s impossible.”

“What?”

“It’s just... paused.”

“Is it a star, then? A satellite?”

“No, it’s definitely a meteor. I just saw it passing, just a second ago.”

“Yea–”

“It shouldn’t have paused, meteors don’t just stop.”

“Maybe–”

“And why is it blinking?”

She stands straight to look at you for a moment before peering again through the scope. You figure she’ll probably get bored and leave soon. You begin cleaning the room as she continuously readjusts the lens. This continues for maybe ten minutes before she becomes frustrated and exits the room while talking to herself.

“That’s just... Wow. I swear– I saw– It was moving!”

She reaches the library table and begins to pack up her stuff. She moves one paper at a time while looking forward, her face a mix of disappointment and deep thought. You stay quiet, not wanting to prolong the situation. It’s 2:15AM and you get to leave at 2:30. You hear her shuffle to the front door in small strides. Her boots squeak against the polished tile with every step. You just hope they’re clean.

Not even a minute later, she walks back into the telescope room.

“Hey.”

“Did you forget something?”

“No it’s just...”

“What?”

“It snowed.”

You look down at her boots, new and sturdy. They seem made to walk through a snowstorm. Your eyes move to your own shoes. Dirty, old white sneakers.

“What’s the problem? Don’t you live on campus?”

“Yeah, but there’s a lot of snow. Like too much to walk through.”

You lean your broom against the wall, walking past the girl, through the library and toward the front entrance. The door is wide open. A wall of white snow forms a blockade four feet high. You’re confused, the grass was completely visible not even an hour ago.

You walk up to the window from earlier, shoving the curtain aside which reveals the same mountain of snow. The girl interjects as you pace back towards the door.

“How could this much snow build up so quickly?”

“I have no idea. It was clear at 1:00. There was no mention of a storm in the forecast.”

“What should we– I mean, can we shovel it?”

“I can try. Maybe it’s just piled high here, against the building.”

You disappear into the maintenance closet and come back holding a shovel. This area gets a lot of snow in the winter, so every building has at least one in storage. You flip it upside down and stick it into the top of the snow bank, pushing the white powder back on top of itself. The snow is surprisingly light. You continue shoveling until there is a wide enough gap to stand in.

You walk through the door, rising as tall as you can to see over the snowbank. It’s the same height far and wide, impossible. As you stand there you notice something else. There’s no wind and the sky is completely clear, not a single snowflake. In fact, it’s warmer outside than it is in the building. You pull off your glove, pressing a palm against the snow. It’s not cold. You grab a clump, but it doesn’t melt in your hand. It’s like the stuff you imagine directors use in place of snow on a set. As if it was packaged in clear bags before arriving here. You look back at the girl,

who is standing with her arms crossed. Her jacket and backpack are still on as if she will be able to leave soon.

“This isn’t snow.”

“What do you mean? What is it then?”

“I don’t know. It’s powder, it’s like fake snow. Feel it.”

You walk towards her with the clump still in your hand, presenting it while some slips through your fingers and onto the floor. She pokes it, and then pinches it, and then grabs the whole pile. She throws it back out the door, onto the floor of the gap you dug out. Based on the glimpse you got of her notebook, you figure she’s pretty smart. Maybe she knows what it is.

“What do you think it is?”

“How would I know?”

“You’d know better than me.”

“Well, I don’t. I have no idea.”

She steps back and shuts the door, painting on the adjacent wall jump with the force of the slam. She approaches the library table and puts her bag down, once again taking out her textbook and pile of papers.

“If I can’t leave, I might as well keep studying.”

You look back at the door. You’ve lived in this area your whole life, experienced a myriad of crazy snowstorms and other weather extremes, but you’ve never seen anything like this. The situation doesn’t make any sense. What it is, where it came from, and how it could pile up so fast with no trace of falling from the sky. You thought that was it, but she continues talking.

“And what about you? When are you supposed to go home?”

You continue looking at the door.

“I’m supposed to leave now.”

“That’s not happening.”

“I guess not.”

You walk over and sit across from her, slumping deep into the old chair. You grab the crumpled paper from your pocket and rub your thumb across the various phone numbers, mouthing the digits slowly. You think about calling your sister back to tell her about this new development, but you look back at the clock and decide to leave it be.

You look back up at the girl, who is writing intensely in her notebook. Somehow, despite the strange circumstances, she’s still able to focus like before. You admire her concentration. It’s something you were never able to do while you were in school. You wonder what she’s working on, what she wants to do in the future and whether it will happen. She taps her pencil against

the desk, and then against her chin before looking back at the door. Now it's clear she isn't really doing homework. She meets your gaze, ready to continue talking. You quickly shove the paper back into your pocket.

"If you think about it, this is actually kind of cool."

"What's cool?"

"The snow— Well, whatever's outside, I mean."

She puts the pencil down and leans back in her chair. The noise it makes is louder than before.

"How's that? We're trapped in here."

"Well yea, but doesn't it feel novel? I think we're experiencing a new kind of weather event."

"To be honest no, it's kind of freaking me out."

"I get that too. I'm nervous, shaky like. But I think some of that is excitement."

"It's good you can feel like that."

"I was pretty bummed before, with the meteor and all. I thought I was finally gonna see one for myself. I was imagining what I would tell my roommate. Man, she'd be so jealous."

You wonder how you should respond. You thought she might have a nobler reason for thinking this moment is special. Before you can think of something, she continues talking.

"But really, I just think it's cool. That's how nature is. It's scary but also fascinating, breathtaking. We live within it, assigning these rules to make sense of something that shouldn't be sensed about. Don't you think so?"

"I'm not sure if I agree, but that's a nice way to view it. Aren't you studying physics?"

"I am, and I love it."

You want to say that you expected her to be more pragmatic. Ask why she threw the "snow" back outside, instead of inspecting it. Why she's not freaking out. That's why you asked the question in the first place, but now it seems rude. She opens her mouth to continue talking, but is interrupted by the radio which has been off for a while. You both turn to face it. It's quiet, barely audible.

"Four two point two nine..."

She jumps from her seat, pushing it back with urgency. That noise. She runs to sit on the floor in front of the radio, knees forward as she fiddles with the volume. You walk over and join her.

"Eight nine three four two point two nine five two five one minus seven—"

You look at her looking at the radio. This is too weird, you need to ask a question.

"What is that? An equation?"

She reaches a hand out, commanding you to stop talking.

“Shh.”

The radio continues.

“two eight nine three four two point two nine five two five one minus seven one three zero two eight nine three four two point two nine five two—”

Her head darts to face you and she covers her mouth.

“What?”

“It’s repeating, two numbers.”

“And? What is it?”

“Don’t you get it, they’re coordinates. North, west. It’s a location.”

“What the fuck? Why is the radio broadcasting this?”

She gets up, nearly tripping as she runs to the table, grabbing a paper and pencil. Turning the paper to its blank side, she begins writing numbers. When finished, she smiles and walks back to you, holding it up, a foot away from your face.

42.295251, -71.302189

You can tell that she’s proud, excited, at this discovery. You’re not. You look at her and grab the paper. She snatches it back, clutching it close to her chest. She walks out of the library and into another room, returning with a map. She unfolds and lays it across the table, flattening the edges with her palms.

“I’m gonna find it.”

“You do that.”

This new development does nothing to calm your nerves. You move the radio dials, trying to switch stations or at least lower the volume, but nothing is working. You grab the chord and follow its trail to the adjacent wall, unplugging it completely. The noise continues.

Before you can even react, the girl makes another discovery.

“It’s here...”

She squints and dips her head closer to the paper.

“It’s literally right here.”

“You found it? Where is it?”

“I need a more zoomed in view. Do you have a campus map?”

“I think there’s one in the closet. Give me a second.”

You retrieve a laminated map and place it in front of her, standing over the chair.

“It’s on campus?”

“Yeah, wait...”

“What?”

“It’s this building. It’s the observatory. Right here...”

She points at the observatory and drags her finger two inches north. She leaves her finger there and uses her other hand to fish for a marker in her pencil case, circling the spot in bright blue ink. She gets up and spins around the room, holding the map in front of her.

“There.”

She points at the wall with the window and the yellow phone. She leans down and places the map on the floor, in front of the radio. At this moment, the radio shuts off. The room is quiet again. You rush past her, bumping her shoulder as you approach the window. You fling open the curtains and put your hand against the glass, hoping to get a better view. The girl stands behind you and uses your shoulder as leverage to peer over.

The “snow” from before is completely gone, you can see outside now. The lamppost is no longer illuminated, but there’s another light in the distance. It’s the shipping container from before. It’s closed, locked with a bar across the front, but a warm light emanates from the cracks of the entrance.

You turn around to look at the girl. She reaches behind to rub her neck, which seems more like a sign of confusion than a self-soothing gesture. She isn’t scared. Her eyebrows furrow as she squints to make out the fine details of the container. You’ve had enough.

“That’s it. I’m done.”

“You’re done? What?”

“Yeah I’m done. I’m calling someone.”

“Who are you calling?”

You don’t want to be sarcastic, but you can’t believe she’s not reacting to this with panic.

“I don’t know, the police?”

“Why? Don’t do that.”

“*Why?* Either we’re being pranked on a \$10,000 budget or there’s some paranormal shit going on here. I don’t want to be part of either scenario.”

“Paranormal? No! Don’t you see?”

“What I see is fake snow and a creepy fucking glowing container.”

You step to the side and grab the phone, dialing 9-1-1 and holding the speaker up to your ear. The girl looks at you with an angry expression. You turn around, your back towards her. The phone doesn’t ring. You hang it up and try again, but it still doesn’t work. You exhale sharply

before slamming it back in place. The whole fixture comes clean off the wall, smashing as it hits the floor. There was nothing connecting it to the outside, no trace of any previous installation. Not a single wire. The wall where it was attached is clean. You bend down to inspect the pieces, holding a yellow bit in between your fingers. It's plastic. A toy.

"What... The..."

Have you gone crazy? You just spoke to your sister on this phone. It was a real phone. There is no logical explanation for this. You clutch your shirt at the chest, almost instinctually. It feels like you've been transported into an episode of *The Twilight Zone*. You don't even like that show. It terrified you as a child and you've avoided it ever since. The irony.

As you sit with your thoughts, the girl leaves the room and comes back. Her hand touches your shoulder. As you stand up to face her, she begins talking.

"I think it's alright."

You brush her hand off of your shoulder.

"No, I don't think it is. What's happening?"

"I don't know, but maybe we're not supposed to know."

"What?"

"Here, I want to show you something."

She walks back through the library and into the telescope room, holding the door for you to pass by. She follows behind you and guides you to look into the lens.

"Come on, look."

You peer through and it's the same as before. The same blinking light, in the same place.

"What? It's the same."

"Yeah, it is."

"Please, just say what you're trying to say."

"I think it's a message. For us, for me, someone here."

You knew this would be her theory, as soon as she realized the coordinates. A student finding herself in this scenario, she wants to feel chosen, special. She wants to make a discovery. Be a first. She wants to tell her roommate.

Or, are you just being cynical? It's not like you have a better explanation. Maybe there's some truth to her theory. If so, you just hope whoever's out there isn't malicious. You figure they aren't, that if they can turn a phone into a plastic with no indication, they surely could've killed you by now. You both walk back into the library and sit at the table. You finally respond to her last statement.

“Who’s sending the message?”

“I don’t know, but does it matter?”

“I think it does. Do you think it’s aliens?”

“Yeah, don’t you?”

“I don’t know, maybe? I don’t really believe in that stuff.”

You realise that the building’s temperature has returned to normal. You take off your coat and fling it on the back of your chair, she leaves hers on. She looks towards the window and responds.

“You don’t believe in aliens, extra-terrestrials, at all? It’s not a controversial opinion, you know. There’s a really high chance they exist. Just maybe not in the way we think, not like in the films.”

“Even so, what would they want with us?”

“I don’t know... Armstrong landed on the moon not seven months ago, maybe they noticed us. Maybe they have questions. This could be the beginning of something new. It doesn’t have to be bad or scary.”

“Is it not scary? It seems like, whoever this is, trapped us here until we knew what they wanted.”

“I guess I’m just optimistic. What do you think? Would something so advanced have morals?”

You think about what she said. Are you making this situation worse than it is? Are you creating a terrifying scenario out of nothing? No, whatever’s happening is weird. It’s out of place, it’s not meant for you. If you went to sleep right now, would it all go away?

“So, what are you gonna do?”

“I’m going outside, to the crate— the coordinates. I’m going to open it.”

The thought is crazy, but it tracks with what she’s been saying. There was no way she was just going to go home. Now that she knows there’s something out there, and that it noticed *her*, she needs to see it through. You don’t want to participate, but if she does, you can’t stop her.

Her jacket is still zipped, but she tugs at it anyway, making sure it’s all the way up. She grabs her backpack and all her papers, placing them neatly inside the various pockets. She bends down next to the radio, picking up the college map. You think about offering her a weapon of some kind, a spade or a crowbar, but you don’t think she’ll take it.

She stands in front of the door, paused, looking forward. She’s waiting for you to say something. You aren’t sure what to say. What would be right? Should you wish her luck? Crack a joke? You don’t know this girl, and you don’t understand why she’s going out there.

She sighs and opens the door, stepping outside and shutting it behind her. It’s actually snowing now, what looks like real snow. There’s a strong wind. You approach the window and watch as she walks against the air. It blows her to the side. Her hood and bag charms fight to stay in place. The campus map slips from her gloved hand and flies into the distance, down a short hill. She looks in its direction for a second, but keeps walking forward.

She reaches the container and lifts the bar with a single, powerful upward motion. The container door opens and reveals a light that shines with such brightness it forces you to look away. The last thing you see is her shadow step inside.

As you are turned away, you notice that the phone is back on the wall. You forget about the container, about the girl, for a second. You dawn a nervous smile as you dial your sister's number and it rings. You hang up before it can ring a second time. You run to the telescope room and look through the lens. There are stars, but the blinking light from before is gone. You approach the window and open the curtains. The container is still there, but it's closed and there's no light.

The clock reads 3:09AM, there's one more train home. You figure you can make it if you leave now. You could just stay the night in the observatory, you have before. But you haven't had time to think about what just happened, and you don't want to be here if it happens again. You quickly gather your belongings, neglecting to put away your cleaning cart or shut off the lights.

Your first few steps outside are cautious, your body facing towards the container as you walk in the opposite direction. At the bottom of the hill, you find the campus map. A corner got stuck under a rock, so it didn't blow far. You pick it up and continue towards the bus, running now.

On the ride home you think about yourself, how you could've never done what she did. Not that you would've wanted to, but even if you did. You were always the kid who was too scared to leave your own bed at night, for fear that your ankles might be grabbed from underneath. You wonder if she felt like that too, when she opened the container. You don't know, but you hope not.

You quit that job the next day. You can find something else, you always do.

The same morning while sitting in bed, you flip through the yellow pages, searching for the college's registration office number. You call them and they answer almost immediately. Before they can say their line, you introduce your question.

"Hey, I'm looking for someone. They go here."

"I'm sorry but I can't give you student information."

"I don't need anything confidential. It's just, my friend goes there and I need to contact her."

The woman doesn't respond. After ten seconds of silence, you think she's probably going to hang up if you don't talk again.

"Please? I'm just worried about her. Her mom is worried too, I can get her on the line."

"That won't be necessary. What's her name?"

"It's Michelle Davis."

"Alright. Please hold."

She is gone for three minutes before returning with information. The time passes slowly. You're surprised the lady on the phone is even checking. You're pretty sure this is against school policy. You think about Michelle, you hope she's doing okay. You think about what she must have told her roommate. You wonder if she's jealous. Before you can think too much, the voice on the phone returns.

"Hello."

"Hey, did you find her?"

"You said Michelle, right? Michelle Davis?"

"Yeah, that's correct."

"No one by that name is registered here."

"What? Are you sure?"

"I'm sure."

"She would be in the class of '72 or '73."

"I'm sorry, you must have the wrong college."

The dial tone plays as the lady hangs up. You stare at the phone before placing it back on the hook. If you went back to the observatory right now, before it was next cleaned, would you find her boot prints? You wonder if the container is still there, what would be inside if you opened it, but you know you'll never go back.

You try not to think about it, but Michelle doesn't leave your mind. Later that night, you check the yellow pages again, twice over. She isn't there. Your town is small, so there are few enough people with the last name Davis for you to call each one and inquire about any Michelle in their family. None of them know of such a girl.

It's about 2pm before you finally decide to leave your room. Stepping out into the living room, you see Jennifer, sitting on the couch with a tub of ice cream in one hand and the newspaper in another. It's a school day, so you expected to be alone in the house.

"Hey, why are you here? Don't you have school?"

"Why am *I* here? I'm sick. Why are *you* here?"

"I quit this morning."

She continues reading the paper as she dips her spoon into the nearly-empty tub and holds it in the corner of her mouth.

"Typical."

"Yeah, maybe."

It's the afternoon now, but you barely got 4 hours of sleep. You stand in the doorway to your room, ready to go back to bed, but you can't shake this horrible oblivious feeling.

"Hey, do you remember when I called you last night?"

"Yeah, frickin' woke me up at 1am. Why?"

"Sorry, it's nothing."

"HAHA, no, it's fine. What's up?"

You pause, thinking about what you even want to ask. She throws the paper onto the cushion and flips around to lean over the back of the couch, facing you.

“Hello?”

“Do you remember the girl, I told you she was studying in the library after hours? Did I say anything else? Like what w—”

She cuts you off mid-sentence.

“Do I remember *the girl*? What girl? You didn’t mention any girl.”

“I did.”

“I think I would remember...”

“No, but... I did.”

“Mhm...”

“I just called the school, they don’t even have her registered as a student.”

“OK, you’re officially coocoo.”

She walks to the kitchen and dumps the ice cream in the recycling bin before quickly rinsing the spoon and placing it into the drawer of utensils. She fixes the newspaper back into its original position on the living room table, before grabbing a magazine from underneath and heading towards her bedroom.

“But...”

“It’s okay to be coocoo.”

“...”

“Also, if you see her today, don’t tell mom I wasn’t at school.”

She closes her door, leaving you alone with your own thoughts.

You finally return to your room and fall onto your bed, laying back and nearly hitting your head on the windowsill. You pick up the map sitting next to you, raising it to your face. The blue circle is smudged but still visible.